a word many people go a lifetime without using. George couldn't go five minutes. Most people dive under a table when they hear this word, but for George it was the Swiss Army knife of language—endless applications and uses. (He also made it sound almost charming, with his Aussie accent.)

It was merely one of dozens of words in the complete George lexicon. For instance, a *fat* was a plump cow ready for slaughter. A *steer* was a young bull that should've been castrated but hadn't been yet. A *weaner* was a calf newly split from its mother. A *smoko* was a cigarette break. *Tucker* was food. I spent a lot of late 2003 sitting high in the saddle, watching a weaner while sucking a smoko and dreaming of my next tucker.

Sometimes hard, sometimes tedious, mustering could be unexpectedly emotional. Young females were easier, they went where you nudged them, but young males didn't care for being bossed around, and what they really didn't like was being split from their mums. They cried, moaned, sometimes charged you. A wildly swung horn could ruin a limb or sever an artery. But I wasn't afraid. Instead…I was empathetic. And the young males seemed to know.

The one job I wouldn't do, the one piece of hard work I shied from, was snipping balls. Every time George brought out that long shiny blade I'd raise my hands. *No, mate, can't do it.*

Suit yourself.

At day's end I'd take a scalding shower, eat a gargantuan supper, then sit with George on the porch, rolling cigarettes, sipping cold beers. Sometimes we'd listen to his small CD player, which made me think of Pa's wireless. Or Henners. *He and the other boy went to borrow another CD player.*…Often we'd just sit gazing into the distance. The land was so tabletop flat you could see thunderstorms brewing hours ahead of when they arrived, the first spidery bolts flicking the far-off land. As the bolts got thicker, and closer, wind would race through the house, ruffling the curtains. Then the rooms would flutter with white light. The first thunderclaps would shake the furniture. Finally, the deluge. George would sigh. His parents would sigh. Rain was grass, rain was fat. Rain was money.

If it didn't rain, that also felt like a blessing, because after a windstorm the clear sky would be peppered with stars. I'd point out to George what the gang in Botswana had pointed out to me. *See that bright one next to the moon? That's Venus. And over there, that's Scorpius—best place to see it is the southern hemisphere. And there's Pleiades. And that's Sirius—brightest star in the sky. And*